

The Marriage Communication Workbook - Printable Worksheets

Every worksheet from the book, one per page. Print as many copies as you need.

The Weekly Meeting Card (twenty minutes, same day each week)

1. Appreciations - two specific things each (3 min)
2. What went well between us this week (3 min)
3. Planning: calendar, money, children, house (5 min)
4. One issue, raised softly: I feel... about... and I need...; the listener reflects before responding; time-out if flooded (7 min)
5. One thing we will do together this week (2 min)

The Time-Out Card

Either of us can say the word. It is honoured without argument.

Twenty minutes apart, doing something calming. No rehearsing the argument.

We come back at the time we said, and the person who called it starts, softly.

Our word: _____ Our usual return time: _____

Worksheet 3.1 - Our agreement

Fill this in together before Week 1.

Our session times this week (two or three, 30-45 min)	
Where (a table, not the bed or the sofa in front of the television)	
Our weekly meeting day and time	
The signal either of us can use to pause ("time out", a hand up, a word)	
What we will each do during a pause (separately, calming, no rehearsing)	
What we hope is different in six weeks (each write your own)	

Worksheet 1.1 - The state of us (each fill in separately)

Rate each 0 (not at all) to 5 (very much).

	Me	My partner (compare after)
I know what is on my partner's mind these days: their worries, their hopes, their week		
I feel fond of my partner most days, and I say so		
When my partner makes a small bid for my attention, I usually respond		
When I think about us overall, I feel mostly positive		
When we disagree, we can talk about it without it becoming a fight		
When a fight goes wrong, we repair it within a day		
I feel we are building something together, with shared goals		
I feel heard by my partner		
I feel that I listen well to my partner		
I feel safe raising a hard subject		

My three lowest scores: _____

Worksheet 1.2 - What we fight about

(each fill in separately)

Topic	How often (rarely / monthly / weekly / daily)	How it usually starts	How it usually ends	Solvable or perpetual? (your guess)
Money				
Chores and the house				
Children / family				
In-laws				
Time together / apart				
Sex and affection				
Work and tiredness				
Phones and screens				
Drinking, health, habits				
Something else				

Worksheet 1.3 - Our pattern (fill in together, after comparing)

Who usually raises things? Who usually withdraws? (Both can be either, depending on the topic.)	
What the raiser does when the withdrawer withdraws	
What the withdrawer does when the raiser raises harder	
Where the pattern most often happens (kitchen at six, car, bed at eleven)	
How a typical episode ends, and how long the cold spell lasts	
The horseman each of us most often uses (criticism / contempt / defensiveness / stonewalling), by our own admission	
One thing we agree about the pattern	

Weekly meeting (twenty minutes; the agenda is in Week 5, use this for now)

Sessions done this week (out of 2-3)	
Appreciations said (each)	
What surprised each of us in the other's answers	
Our three lowest joint scores, which the program will work on	
One thing that went well this week between us	

Worksheet 2.1 - Listening practice log

Do the speaker-listener exercise three times this week, ten minutes each, on a *low-heat* topic (something mildly annoying, not the big one). Record it.

Session	Topic (low heat)	The feeling I heard under it	Did the speaker say "yes, that's it" on the first try, or after correction?	What was hard about listening
1				
2				
3				

Worksheet 2.2 - The feelings and needs list (keep it open during practice)

Feelings people are usually having under a complaint	Needs usually under the feeling
Frustrated, ignored, unimportant	To matter; to be noticed
Hurt, criticised, small	To be respected; to be seen as trying
Lonely, shut out, invisible	To be close; to be let in
Tired, overwhelmed, alone with it	To be helped; to share the load
Anxious, unsafe, uncertain	To be reassured; to know where we stand
Resentful, taken for granted	To be appreciated; fairness
Afraid, protective	To be safe; to protect the children / the home
Bored, restless	Fun; novelty; adventure together

Worksheet 2.3 - The stress-reducing conversation log

Day	Did it (Y/N)	What my partner's day had in it	What I said that took their side	What I wanted to say instead (advice, correction) and did not
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Weekly meeting

Speaker-listener sessions done	
Stress-reducing conversations done (out of 7)	
A time this week one of us felt heard, and what the listener did	
The reflex we each noticed in ourselves (advising, defending, correcting, fixing)	
One thing that went well	

Worksheet 3.1 - Translating criticism into complaint (each, separately)

Write three things you have actually said, or thought, recently. Rewrite each.

What I said (or thought)	I feel...	...about...	...and I need...

Worksheet 3.2 - Softened start-up practice (together)

Each of you delivers one rewritten complaint from 3.1 using the speaker-listener structure from Week 2: speaker delivers the softened start-up; listener reflects the feeling and the need; then, and only then, the listener responds.

Who spoke	The start-up as delivered	Listener's reflection	Did the speaker feel heard?	What the listener offered

Worksheet 3.3 - My criticism habits (each, separately, honestly)

The phrase	How often I use it	What I could say instead
"You always..."		
"You never..."		
"Why can't you just..."		
"What is wrong with you" / "typical"		
A sigh, an eye-roll, silence that means something		
Raising three things at once		

Weekly meeting

Softened start-ups attempted this week (each)	
One that worked, and why	
One that went wrong, and where it went wrong (the wording, the timing, the response)	
The criticism habit each of us caught in ourselves	
One thing that went well	

Worksheet 4.1 - Our time-out agreement (together)

The word or signal either of us can use	
What each of us will do for the twenty minutes (separately, calming)	
How we say when we will come back ("in half an hour", "after dinner")	
The one rule for the return (start softly; the listener reflects first)	
The signs of flooding each of us recognises in ourselves	
The signs each of us sees in the other	

Worksheet 4.2 - Catching the horsemen (each, separately, this week)

Day	Horseman I caught in myself (C / Con / D / S)	What I said or did	The antidote I used, or could have	Horseman I saw in my partner (noted, not raised)
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

Worksheet 4.3 - Our repair phrases (together)

Choose six you would each actually say, and practise saying them out loud now, when nothing is wrong, so they are available when something is.

Repair attempts that lower the heat	We will use
"Can we start that again?"	
"I'm sorry, that came out wrong."	
"You have a point." / "That's fair."	
"I'm getting flooded; I need twenty minutes and I'll come back."	
"I'm not trying to win. I'm trying to be understood."	
"Let me try to say what I heard."	
"I love you and I hate this."	
"Can I have a hug before we carry on?"	
"What do you need from me right now?"	
Our own:	

Worksheet 4.4 - The aftermath of a fight (together, after one)

Do this for one real fight this week or a recent one, calm, using the speaker-listener structure.

	Me	My partner
How I felt during it (feelings only)		
What I needed and did not get		
The moment it went wrong (a trigger, a horseman, flooding)		
My part in it (one thing, no "but")		
What I could do differently next time		
What would help me from you next time		

Weekly meeting

Time-outs called this week, and returns made	
Horsemen each of us caught most in ourselves	
Repair attempts made; repair attempts accepted	
The aftermath conversation: what we learned	
One thing that went well	

Worksheet 5.1 - Bid watching (each, separately, three days)

Day	Bids I noticed from my partner (count)	Turned toward / away / against (rough counts)	A bid I nearly missed and caught	A bid I made that was missed, and how it felt
1				
2				
3				

Worksheet 5.2 - Fondness and admiration

(each, separately, then read to each other)

Finish each sentence about your partner. Read them aloud in the weekly meeting. This is the exercise people are most embarrassed by and most moved by.

One thing you did this week I was grateful for	
A quality of yours I admire, with an example from this month	
Something you are better at than me	
A time you were there for me	
What I first noticed about you	
Something I still find attractive about you	
A moment this year I felt proud to be with you	

Worksheet 5.3 - Our rituals of connection (together)

Ritual	Do we have it now?	What it looks like / could look like	When
Parting in the morning			
Reuniting in the evening			
Meals together (which ones, no screens)			
Going to bed			
A weekly date or outing			
Something just the two of us do (a walk, a programme, a game)			
Celebrating (birthdays, anniversaries, small wins)			
A holiday or a night away			

Worksheet 5.4 - The weekly meeting agenda (copy onto the card)

Step	Minutes	What happens
1. Appreciations	3	Each says two specific things the other did this week
2. What went well	3	Between us, this week
3. Planning	5	Calendar, money, children, house: the logistics, briefly
4. One issue	7	One, raised softly (Week 3); speaker-listener (Week 2); no horsemen (Week 4); if it floods, time-out and return
5. Looking forward	2	One thing we will do together this week

Weekly meeting (use the agenda from now on)

Bids: what each of us noticed about our own turning toward / away	
Fondness sheets read aloud: how it felt	
Rituals we agreed to restart or start	
The one issue raised, and how it went	
One thing that went well	

Worksheet 6.1 - Our perpetual problems (together, from Week 1's list)

The problem	Solvable (a situation) or perpetual (a difference)?	Is it gridlocked? (the same fight, harder, no humour)

Worksheet 6.2 - The dream within the conflict (each, separately, for one gridlocked problem; then speak it, using the speaker-listener structure)

The problem	
My position, in one sentence	
What this is really about for me: the value, the dream, the story from earlier in my life	
What I am afraid would happen if I gave way	
What I hope my partner will understand about this	

Worksheet 6.3 - Core and flexible (each, separately, then together)

	Me	My partner
My core: what I cannot give up on this		
My flexible area: where I can move		
The overlap we found		
The temporary compromise we will try for a month		
The date we will review it		

Worksheet 6.4 - What we are building (together)

Three things we both want the next five years to hold	
The roles each of us plays that we are happy with, and one we want to change	
A ritual we want our household to be known for	
What we stand for, as a couple (the values we would want our children or friends to see)	
One thing from these six weeks we will never let lapse	

Weekly meeting - and the six-week review

Our State of Us scores now (repeat Worksheet 1.1) vs Week 1	
The three changes that made the most difference	
The horseman each of us has most reduced	
The perpetual problem we now talk about differently	
The weekly meeting: day and time, in the calendar, for good	
What each of us would tell the couple we were in Week 1	

Worksheet 7.1 - Our maintenance plan (together)

Weekly meeting: day, time, where	
Daily appreciation: when (attached to what)	
Stress-reducing conversation: when	
Our time-out word and return rule (from Week 4)	
The drift signs we are each most prone to	
What we will do when we notice two of them	
The big-fight protocol, in our own words	
The date we will redo the State of Us (Worksheet 1.1): three months from now	

Blank softened start-up

I feel...	...about...	...and I need...

Blank aftermath of a fight

	Me	My partner
How I felt during it		
What I needed		
The moment it went wrong		
My part in it		
What I could do differently		
What would help me from you		

Blank weekly meeting

Step	Notes
1. Appreciations (two each)	
2. What went well	
3. Planning	
4. One issue (softly; speaker-listener)	
5. Looking forward	

Blank dream within the conflict

The problem	
My position	
What it is really about for me	
What I fear if I give way	
What I hope you will understand	

The twelve-week tracker

Week	Weekly meeting held	Appreciations (days out of 7)	Time-outs called / returned	Notes
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				
7				
8				
9				
10				
11				
12				

Print more copies of every worksheet from the link at the front of the book.